

Mika Asaba, PhD

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UX researcher with 10+ years at the intersection of early childhood development, behavioral science, and applied product research. I specialize in translating qualitative and behavioral insights into product decisions for student- and family-facing AI tools, with deep expertise working with children ages 0–6 and their caregivers. A founding member of two academic research labs at Stanford and Yale and my current research initiative, Tangle & Thrive, at Teaching Lab Studio, I have a consistent track record of building research culture and teams in early-stage environments.

METHODS & SKILLS

Qualitative Research: User interviews, usability testing, concept testing, diary studies, behavioral observation, think-aloud protocols, thematic analysis

Research Design & Evaluation: Experimental design, mixed-methods evaluation, rapid-cycle prototyping and iteration, survey design, behavioral coding

Data & Statistics: R, mixed-effects modeling, Bayesian analysis, data visualization

AI & Systems: LLM prompt engineering and evaluation, automated classification pipelines, A/B testing, AI-assisted annotation

Collaboration: Cross-functional partnership with engineers, designers, educators, and families; funder and internal stakeholder communication; mentorship of junior researchers

EXPERIENCE

Teaching Lab Studio

Seattle, WA

AI Fellow, Tangle & Thrive

2025–Present

- Founded and built research and product development initiative at Teaching Lab Studio from the ground up, establishing research processes, methods, and team culture for a new consumer product initiative focused on student engagement and motivation.
- Evaluated student, caregiver, and educator experiences with AI-enabled mobile- and web-based educational tools through interviews and surveys; translated user feedback into feature design priorities and iterative product improvements.
- Designed and ran experiments (n=100+ families) testing AI-delivered caregiver SMS conversations; achieved 80% completion rates and statistically significant improvements in student math interest and math anxiety.
- Operationalized learning science theories into evaluation metrics and analysis pipelines to guide iterative product development in collaboration with engineers, instructional coaches, and school partners.
- Synthesized and presented research findings and tool updates to funders and internal stakeholders; mentor junior researchers and design associates.

Yale University

New Haven, CT

Postdoctoral Research Associate

2021–2025 Advisors: Julia Leonard, Julián Jara-Ettinger

- Extended foundational research on young children to examine how motivation and social cognition develop through adolescence, including how students evaluate the credibility of feedback and encouragement from others. Published 12 articles in top cognitive science and developmental psychology journals.
- Collaborated on a study (n=217 parents of 4-to-5-year-olds) testing how message framing influences caregiver behavior; found that framing tasks as learning opportunities reduced

parental takeover by nearly half, directly informing how digital products can guide caregivers in fostering early development.

- Designed and administered large-scale surveys (n=1,500+) to understand adolescent motivation across the United States; applied computational modeling and Bayesian methods to behavioral data.
- Ensured project alignment with legal and ethical standards by developing robust research protocols for IRB approval and implementing strict data privacy frameworks to protect participant information.
- As a founding lab member, played a central role in shaping research culture and mentoring incoming researchers as the team grew from 5 to 15; supervised senior thesis students; presented at CogSci, SPSP, and SRCD.

Stanford University

Graduate Research Fellow, PhD

Stanford, CA

2016–2021 Advisor: Hyowon Gweon

- Conducted a program of research on how infants, toddlers, and preschoolers (ages 0–6) reason about mental states, verbal feedback, emotional expressions, in service of learning.
- Designed and ran behavioral experiments with young children and their caregivers at local partner schools, museum sites, and online platforms; developed novel experimental paradigms adopted by subsequent collaborators.
- As a founding lab member, helped build the lab’s research infrastructure and onboard new researchers; received NSF Graduate Research Fellowship; served as primary instructor for Developmental Psychology and General Psychology.

EDUCATION

Stanford University

Ph.D., Psychology

Stanford, CA

2021

Wellesley College

B.A., Neuroscience

Wellesley, MA

2014

GRANTS & AWARDS

Teaching Lab Studio Fellowship (\$1,000,000)

2025-Present

NSF SBE Postdoctoral Fellowship (\$138,000)

2022-2024

Character Lab Research Network Grant (\$40,000)

2021-2022

NSF Graduate Research Fellowship (\$40,000)

2017-2020

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- **Asaba, M.**, Ong, D. C., & Gweon, H. (2019). Integrating expectations and outcomes: Preschoolers’ developing ability to reason about others’ emotions. *Developmental Psychology*, 55(8), 1680–1693.
- **Asaba, M.** & Gweon, H. (2022). Young children infer and manage what others think about them. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 119(32), e2105642119.
- **Asaba, M.**, Stegall, J., Hembacher, E., Frank, M.C., & Gweon, H. (2025). Young children infer the informativeness of praise. *Developmental Psychology*. Advance Online Publication.
- Shachnai, R., **Asaba, M.**, Hu, L., & Leonard, J. A. (2025). Pointing out learning opportunities reduces overparenting. *Child Development*, 96(2), 679–690.

Full publication list available at masaba.github.io/papers